

Veterans Backbone – Training & Ongoing Standards Framework

Purpose

Veterans Backbone believes that good intentions are not enough.

Supporting people safely and effectively requires appropriate knowledge, practical skills, sound judgement, and a commitment to continual learning.

This framework sets out how Veterans Backbone maintains competence, accountability, supervision, and professional standards across all roles.

Training is not treated as a one-off exercise. It is an ongoing process that supports safety, consistency, wellbeing, and service quality.

Scope

This framework applies to:

- Employees
 - Volunteers
 - Trustees
 - Contractors
 - External professionals operating within Veterans Backbone services
 - Any individual acting on behalf of Veterans Backbone
-

Core Principles

Veterans Backbone operates on the following principles:

Competence Before Confidence

People should be appropriately trained and supported before taking on responsibilities.

Confidence without competence creates risk.

Learning Never Stops

Training is not considered complete because a course has been attended.

Learning is continuous and develops through:

- Training
 - Supervision
 - Reflection
 - Experience
 - Feedback
 - Professional development
-

Standards Protect Everyone

Clear standards protect:

- Veterans
- Staff
- Volunteers
- Trustees
- Partner organisations
- The charity itself

Standards exist to create consistency, fairness, and accountability.

Human Judgement Matters

Training supports decision-making but does not replace judgement.

Policies, procedures, qualifications, and systems should support good decisions, not replace critical thinking.

Mandatory Training

All relevant staff and volunteers receive training appropriate to their role.

Core mandatory training may include:

- Safeguarding (Adults)
- Professional Boundaries
- Health & Safety
- Equality, Dignity & Respect
- Data Protection & Confidentiality
- Incident Reporting
- Substance-Free Environment Expectations
- Code of Conduct

Training requirements may vary depending on responsibilities.

Role-Specific Training

Additional training may be required depending on role.

Examples include:

- Trauma-aware practice
- De-escalation and conflict management
- Risk assessment
- Transport and safeguarding
- Land-based activity safety
- Volunteer supervision
- Leadership and management
- First aid
- Fire safety

Training should always be proportionate to risk and responsibility.

Induction Standards

Before undertaking duties, individuals should receive an appropriate induction.

Induction may include:

- Understanding Veterans Backbone's purpose and culture
- Safeguarding responsibilities
- Professional boundaries
- Site rules and expectations
- Emergency procedures
- Health and safety arrangements
- Role-specific responsibilities

No individual should be placed into a role without suitable induction.

Supervision & Support

Training alone is not sufficient.

People require ongoing support and supervision to remain safe, effective, and confident in their role.

Supervision exists to:

- Review practice
- Discuss concerns
- Support wellbeing
- Identify development needs
- Maintain accountability
- Reduce burnout and isolation

Nobody should be expected to carry significant responsibility without appropriate support.

Continuous Professional Development

Veterans Backbone encourages ongoing learning and development.

This may include:

- Refresher training
- Workshops
- Mentoring
- Peer learning
- Professional qualifications
- Skills development opportunities

Development should remain relevant to role requirements and organisational needs.

Competence & Accountability

Completion of training does not automatically indicate competence.

Competence is demonstrated through:

- Behaviour
- Decision-making
- Professional conduct
- Consistent application of learning
- Ability to work within role boundaries

Where concerns arise regarding competence, additional support, supervision, or training may be required.

Maintaining Standards

Veterans Backbone maintains standards through:

- Training records
- Supervision records
- Observation and feedback
- Incident reviews
- Complaints and concerns processes
- Safeguarding oversight
- Periodic policy review

Standards are monitored to support learning and improvement, not to create unnecessary bureaucracy.

Learning From Mistakes

Mistakes should be addressed honestly and constructively.

Where issues arise, the focus should be:

- Understanding what happened
- Reducing future risk
- Supporting learning
- Improving systems

Accountability remains important, but learning is essential.

Review & Oversight

This framework is reviewed periodically to ensure it remains relevant, practical, and aligned with organisational needs.

Material changes may be recorded through the Adaptive Stewardship process where appropriate.

Final Statement

Veterans Backbone does not expect perfection.

We do expect people to learn, develop, seek support when needed, and take responsibility for maintaining safe and professional standards.

Training is not about collecting certificates.

It is about ensuring the right people have the right knowledge, support, and judgement to serve veterans safely and effectively.